



Down and out: India was knocked out of the T20 World Cup at the group stage by a six-wicket defeat by Australia. AFP

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PowerPlay promise, middle-over drift: How India lost its way at the Women's T20 World Cup

India's Women's T20 World Cup campaign ended in another group-stage exit. A **closer look** at the batting, bowling and tactical shortcomings.

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And then it was 10. As Georgia Wareham drove down the Lord's slope and into the boundary, India's wait for a maiden Women's T20 World Cup title stretched into a 10th edition.

For the second tournament in a row, Harmanpreet Kaur and Co. suffered a group-stage exit, paying the price for crucial defeats to South Africa and Australia in an unforgiving format that left no room for error.

History repeats itself

Hopes were high for India. The reigning ODI champion had one of the most talented batting units in international cricket, and a squad strengthened by experience at the highest level in the Women's Premier League.

The team also prepared by touring Australia (three matches), South Africa (five matches), and England (three matches) for the T20I series against all three sides, each of which ultimately reached the semifinals of the tournament.

The South Africa and England series ended in defeat (4-1 and 2-1

respectively). With hindsight, some may view those losses as a warning of what lay ahead, but they also gave a young side valuable preparation against the strongest opposition in the toughest conditions.

By the end of the World Cup, however, things looked much the same as they had at the end of the 2024 edition. India was knocked out of that tournament after defeats to New Zealand and Australia.

In 2026, it beat Pakistan, the Netherlands, and Bangladesh, but lost to South Africa and Australia, leaving Harmanpreet lamenting India's performances against the tournament's strongest sides.

"If I have to think about the entire tournament, I think we didn't play well enough against the good teams," she told broadcasters after the Australia defeat. "As a group, we really have to rethink what we do against (those) good teams."

Is good enough really good enough?

Both of India's defeats followed a similar pattern. It won the toss and opted to bat first on both occasions, posting totals that proved to be around par.

Each effort was respectable, but ultimately fell short of winning totals as India's batting plateaued after the PowerPlay. Although scoring never stalled, the final flourish arrived too late on both occasions.

Across both matches, 15 of the 28 post-PowerPlay overs went for six to nine runs, but only six went for 10 or more. Only against Australia did India string together consecutive 10-plus overs, in the 19th and 20th, an indication that it never managed to move through the gears in its innings. Most tellingly, Richa Ghosh, India's designated finisher, managed a collective 16 from 15 balls with two boundaries, while Shafali Verma was the only batter to face at least 10 balls and score at a strike rate above 120 in both games.

Muddled bowling plans

India may have managed par totals, but its performance with the ball was a more glaring issue. The bowlers